HEALTH

Bread on the table, and diabetes

What the grain has kept matters more than whether bread is eaten at all.

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Two loaves, wheat grains and a glass of water. · AI-generated image

When it comes to bread on the table, what the grain has kept matters more than whether bread is eaten at all. The WHO notes that adults living with diabetes rose from about 200 million in 1990 to about 830 million in 2022; most have type 2 diabetes, closely linked to excess weight and low activity. [1] Research separates whole grain, which keeps the bran and the germ, from refined grain, which is mostly starch. People eating about three servings of whole grains a day had roughly a third lower risk of developing type 2 diabetes than those eating almost none, while refined grains showed no such association. [2]

Analyses following nearly 195,000 adults for decades reached similar results for whole-grain foods like dark bread, oatmeal and cereals. [3] The usual explanation lies in fibre and structure: starch from white flour raises blood sugar fast, while bran slows digestion and prolongs fullness. These studies observe what people eat rather than assign it, and people who choose whole grains may differ in other ways. A brown colour, too, is not proof of whole grain, which makes label-reading essential.

Sources

1. World Health Organization – Diabetes fact sheet
https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/diabetes

2. Aune, Norat, Romundstad & Vatten – Whole grain and refined grain consumption and the risk of type 2 diabetes (European Journal of Epidemiology, 2013)
https://doi.org/10.1007/s10654-013-9852-5

3. Hu et al. – Intake of whole grain foods and risk of type 2 diabetes (BMJ, 2020)
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